

Team Information

Team Name:

AIDI

Team Members:

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Initial Real Problem:

International students applying to U.S. undergraduate programs often struggle to find reliable, organized, and personalized information about schools and the application process. They may not know which schools fit their profile, what materials they need to prepare, how to understand deadlines, or where to find trustworthy information beyond rankings and scattered online posts. This creates confusion, stress, and wasted time, especially for students applying independently or without access to expensive college counseling services.

Worst Possible Idea

Worst Possible Idea 1: Ranking Only School Recommender

Real problem: International students struggle to find U.S. colleges that actually fit them, so they often rely too heavily on rankings and scattered online information.

Bad idea: Build a platform that recommends schools only based on U.S. News rankings. The higher the ranking, the better the fit.

Yes, and it also...

- Assumes every student should apply to Ivy League and Top 20 schools.
- Ignores budget, major, location, admissions chances, and campus culture.
- Tells every student, "Harvard is your best match."
- Ranks schools higher if they pay for advertising.
- Does not include safety schools because they are "not ambitious enough."

Flip: What is actually good in it? Students do need a school recommendation tool, but it should not be based only on rankings. A better version would match students with schools based on academic background, budget, intended major, location preferences, admissions difficulty, campus culture, and international student support.

Worst Possible Idea 2: Overcomplicated Application Roadmap

Real problem: International students often do not understand the U.S. undergraduate application process, including what to prepare, when to prepare it, and how each step fits together.

Bad idea: Build an application roadmap platform where every step has a 50-page explanation, and users must read all the rules before they can start.

Yes, and it also...

- Sends 20 deadline reminders per day.
- Puts Common App, SAT, TOEFL, recommendation letters, essays, transcripts, and portfolios all on one confusing page.
- Uses application jargon without explaining it.
- Says "prepare early" without explaining what early actually means.
- If a student misses one step, it only says, "You failed. Try again next year."

Flip: What is actually good in it? Students need a clear application roadmap, but it should be simple, personalized, and actionable. A better version would generate a step-by-step checklist and deadline tracker based on the student's grade level, application timeline, and target schools.

Worst Possible Idea 3: Random Current Student Matching

Real problem: International students lack direct access to current students or alumni, making it hard to understand the real student experience at U.S. colleges.

Bad idea: Build a platform that randomly connects applicants with current students, without considering school, major, country, language, interests, or background.

Yes, and it also...

- Matches a business applicant with a classics major.

- Matches someone interested in New York schools with a student in Alaska.
- Allows the applicant to ask only one question.
- Automatically rewrites every question to sound formal and generic.
- Does not verify whether the "current student" actually attends the school.
- Tells users, "If nobody replies, please wait 6-8 weeks."

Flip: What is actually good in it? Talking to real current students can be extremely valuable, but the matching needs to be specific and trustworthy. A better version would match applicants with verified students based on school, major, country or region, application background, and interests.

Worst Possible Idea 4: Expensive Counselor Simulator

Real problem: International students often feel lost when applying independently, but private college counseling services are expensive and vary widely in quality.

Bad idea: Build an AI application assistant that charges users for every answer and constantly pushes them to buy a premium counseling package.

Yes, and it also...

- Gives one free answer: "This is a complicated question."
- Charges users to unlock the next sentence.
- Gives vague advice like "be unique" or "show your passion."
- Recommends the most expensive service package no matter what the student actually needs.
- Makes students feel that applying without a counselor means they will definitely fail.

Flip: What is actually good in it? Students do need affordable and transparent application guidance. A better version would provide structured self-service tools, such as material checklists, timelines, essay feedback, school selection support, and real application examples at a lower cost than traditional counseling.

Worst Possible Idea 5: Unfiltered Information Dump

Real problem: International students have difficulty finding reliable information about U.S. colleges because information is scattered across official websites, forums, social media, rankings, and counseling agencies.

Bad idea: Build a platform that dumps every piece of school-related information into one place, including official pages, forum posts, TikTok videos, Reddit comments, and agency advertisements, without filtering or organizing anything.

Yes, and it also...

- Does not show the source or date of the information.
- Treats a 2017 application story as current advice.
- Makes students decide on their own what is trustworthy.
- Displays official admissions requirements and random online guesses at the same level.
- Returns 3,000 unorganized results when a user searches for "NYU."

Flip: What is actually good in it? Students do need a centralized source of information, but the value is not just having more information. A better version would organize school information clearly by admissions requirements, cost, majors, location, student life, and international student support, while showing sources and update dates.

Expand with AI

Flipped Idea 1: Multi-Dimensional School Matching

Problem:

International students struggle to find U.S. colleges that actually fit them because they often rely too heavily on rankings and scattered online information.

Starting Idea:

Create a school matching tool that recommends colleges based on multiple factors, including academic background, budget, intended major, location preferences, admissions difficulty, campus culture, and international student support.

1. Personalized Fit-Based School List

Specific problem: International students do not know which schools are realistic, safe, or ambitious for their profile.

Why this persona cares: They do not want to waste application fees and time applying to schools that are poor fits.

Simple solution concept: A tool that creates a balanced school list with reach, target, and safety schools based on the student's profile.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 9/10

2. Budget-Aware College Matching

Specific problem: Students often discover too late that their preferred schools are financially unrealistic.

Why this persona cares: Tuition, scholarships, financial aid, and cost of living can decide whether they can attend.

Simple solution concept: A school matching tool that filters colleges by estimated total cost, scholarship availability, and international financial aid options.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 9/10

3. Major-Based School Discovery

Specific problem: Students often choose schools based on name recognition instead of the strength of their intended major.

Why this persona cares: A school may be highly ranked overall but weak or limited in the student's specific academic interest.

Simple solution concept: A recommender that ranks schools by program strength, course offerings, research opportunities, and career outcomes in the student's intended field.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 8/10

4. Location and Lifestyle Fit Finder

Specific problem: International students may not understand how much location affects their college experience.

Why this persona cares: Weather, transportation, city size, safety, internships, and community all affect daily life.

Simple solution concept: A matching tool that compares schools based on location preferences, climate, city type, transportation, and lifestyle factors.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 7/10

5. Admissions Difficulty Estimator

Specific problem: International students have trouble understanding how competitive a school is for their profile.

Why this persona cares: They need to build a realistic application strategy instead of only applying to dream schools.

Simple solution concept: A tool that estimates admissions difficulty using GPA, test scores, curriculum, activities, intended major, and historical admit ranges.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 9/10

6. International Student Support Score

Specific problem: Students do not know which schools provide strong support for international students.

Why this persona cares: Visa support, orientation, career services, language support, and community can affect adjustment and success.

Simple solution concept: A school profile feature that scores colleges based on international student services and student reviews.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 8/10

7. Family-Friendly School Comparison

Specific problem: Parents and students often care about different factors when choosing schools.

Why this persona cares: Parents may focus on safety, cost, ranking, and outcomes, while students care about fit and experience.

Simple solution concept: A comparison dashboard that lets students and parents weigh different priorities and see where they agree or disagree.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 7/10

8. Hidden-Gem School Discovery

Specific problem: International students often overlook strong schools that are not globally famous.

Why this persona cares: They may miss schools with better fit, better scholarships, or stronger programs.

Simple solution concept: A discovery tool that recommends lesser-known schools based on student goals and explains why they are strong matches.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 8/10

9. School Culture Match

Specific problem: Official websites do not clearly communicate campus culture.

Why this persona cares: Students want to know whether they would feel comfortable, supported, and socially connected.

Simple solution concept: A culture matching feature that uses student reviews, clubs, campus size, social life, and diversity data to suggest schools.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 7/10

10. Application Strategy Optimizer

Specific problem: Students do not know how many schools to apply to or how to balance their list.

Why this persona cares: Applying to too many schools is expensive and stressful, but applying to too few is risky.

Simple solution concept: A tool that recommends an optimized number and mix of schools based on goals, risk tolerance, and budget.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 8/10

Flipped Idea 2: Personalized Application Roadmap

Problem:

International students often do not understand the U.S. undergraduate application process, including what to prepare, when to prepare it, and how each step fits together.

Starting Idea:

Create a personalized application roadmap that gives students a clear, step-by-step checklist and deadline tracker based on their grade level, application timeline, and target schools.

1. Personalized Application Timeline

Specific problem: Students do not know when to start each part of the application process.

Why this persona cares: Missing one deadline can damage their chances or force them to wait another year.

Simple solution concept: A personalized timeline that breaks the application process into monthly or weekly tasks.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 10/10

2. Target School Deadline Tracker

Specific problem: Different schools have different deadlines for Early Decision, Early Action, Regular Decision, scholarships, and documents.

Why this persona cares: International students often apply across multiple systems and can easily miss requirements.

Simple solution concept: A dashboard that tracks all deadlines by school and sends reminders before each due date.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 9/10

3. Required Materials Checklist

Specific problem: Students are unsure which materials each school requires.

Why this persona cares: Requirements may include transcripts, test scores, essays, recommendation letters, portfolios, financial documents, and English proficiency scores.

Simple solution concept: A school-specific checklist that shows required, optional, and missing materials.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 10/10

4. Essay Planning Assistant

Specific problem: Students do not know how to manage multiple essays across different schools.

Why this persona cares: Writing essays is time-consuming, and prompts can overlap in confusing ways.

Simple solution concept: A tool that organizes essay prompts, identifies reusable themes, and helps students plan drafts.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 8/10

5. Recommendation Letter Tracker

Specific problem: Students are unsure when and how to ask teachers for recommendation letters.

Why this persona cares: Late or weak recommendation letters can hurt the application.

Simple solution concept: A tracker that helps students choose recommenders, prepare request materials, and monitor submission status.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 8/10

6. Testing Plan Builder

Specific problem: International students are confused about SAT, ACT, TOEFL, IELTS, Duolingo, and test-optional policies.

Why this persona cares: Testing affects cost, timing, eligibility, and application strategy.

Simple solution concept: A testing planner that recommends what tests to take and when based on target schools.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 9/10

7. Visa and Post-Admission Roadmap

Specific problem: Students often focus only on admission and do not know what happens after acceptance.

Why this persona cares: Visa documents, deposits, housing, health forms, and travel planning are also stressful.

Simple solution concept: A post-admission checklist for I-20 forms, visa interviews, deposits, housing, and arrival preparation.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 8/10

8. Application Progress Dashboard

Specific problem: Students lose track of what is finished, what is in progress, and what still needs attention.

Why this persona cares: The application process has many moving parts across many schools.

Simple solution concept: A dashboard that shows each school's application status, missing items, upcoming deadlines, and completed tasks.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 9/10

9. First-Generation Applicant Guide

Specific problem: Students whose families are unfamiliar with U.S. admissions may not know basic application concepts.

Why this persona cares: They cannot rely on parents or local school counselors for detailed guidance.

Simple solution concept: A beginner-friendly guide that explains key terms like ED, EA, RD, FAFSA, CSS Profile, transcript, and recommendation letter.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 8/10

10. Common Mistake Prevention Tool

Specific problem: Students make avoidable mistakes, such as submitting late, misunderstanding optional materials, or sending the wrong documents.

Why this persona cares: Small mistakes can have large consequences in admissions.

Simple solution concept: A warning system that flags likely mistakes before submission based on each school's requirements.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 9/10

Flipped Idea 5: Curated College Information Platform

Problem:

International students have difficulty finding reliable information about U.S. colleges because information is scattered across official websites, forums, social media, rankings, and counseling agencies.

Starting Idea:

Create a centralized information platform that organizes reliable school information by admissions requirements, cost, majors, location, student life, and international student support, while showing sources and update dates.

1. Verified School Information Hub

Specific problem: Students do not know which college information is accurate or up to date.

Why this persona cares: Outdated or incorrect information can lead to bad application decisions.

Simple solution concept: A school information hub that pulls from official sources and clearly shows update dates.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 9/10

2. Admissions Requirement Comparison Tool

Specific problem: Students have to visit many school websites to compare requirements.

Why this persona cares: Requirements differ by school and can be hard to find.

Simple solution concept: A comparison table showing deadlines, essays, tests, English proficiency requirements, portfolios, and financial documents.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 10/10

3. International Student Cost Breakdown

Specific problem: Students cannot easily understand the full cost of attendance.

Why this persona cares: Tuition is only one part of the total cost; housing, insurance, food, travel, and personal expenses matter too.

Simple solution concept: A cost breakdown page for each school with tuition, living costs, fees, aid options, and estimated total yearly cost.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 9/10

4. Source Transparency Feature

Specific problem: Students see advice online but cannot tell where it came from.

Why this persona cares: They need to distinguish official requirements from opinions, rumors, and advertisements.

Simple solution concept: Each piece of information includes a source label, such as official website, student review, government data, or user-submitted experience.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 8/10

5. Student Experience Database

Specific problem: Official school websites do not show what daily student life is really like.

Why this persona cares: International students want to understand academics, social life, safety, food, housing, and support.

Simple solution concept: A database of verified student reviews organized by topic and school.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 8/10

6. Major and Career Outcome Explorer

Specific problem: Students struggle to connect majors with future career opportunities.

Why this persona cares: Many international students choose schools partly based on career outcomes and job prospects.

Simple solution concept: A tool that shows popular majors, career paths, internship opportunities, and outcomes for international students.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 8/10

7. Scholarship and Financial Aid Finder

Specific problem: International students do not know which schools offer scholarships or financial aid to non-U.S. citizens.

Why this persona cares: Financial aid can determine whether they can attend a school.

Simple solution concept: A searchable database of schools with merit scholarships, need-based aid, and international student funding options.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 9/10

8. Country-Specific Applicant Notes

Specific problem: Application requirements may vary depending on the student's country or education system.

Why this persona cares: Students need to know how their curriculum, grades, transcripts, and exams are understood by U.S. colleges.

Simple solution concept: Country-specific guides explaining transcript expectations, testing norms, and common application issues.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 7/10

9. Information Overload Filter

Specific problem: Students feel overwhelmed by too much information and do not know what matters most.

Why this persona cares: Too much unorganized information creates stress instead of clarity.

Simple solution concept: A filtered view that shows the most important information first based on the student's stage in the application process.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 8/10

10. School Profile Snapshot

Specific problem: Students need a quick way to understand a school before deciding whether to research it more deeply.

Why this persona cares: Researching every school from scratch takes too much time.

Simple solution concept: A one-page school snapshot with admissions difficulty, cost, strongest majors, location, international student percentage, deadlines, and key pros and cons.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 9/10

Dot Voting

Personalized Fit-Based School List

Specific problem: International students do not know which schools are realistic, safe, or ambitious for their profile.

Why this persona cares: They do not want to waste application fees and time applying to schools that are poor fits.

Simple solution concept: A tool that creates a balanced school list with reach, target, and safety schools based on the student's profile.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 9/10

Admissions Difficulty Estimator

Specific problem: International students have trouble understanding how competitive a school is for their profile.

Why this persona cares: They need to build a realistic application strategy instead of only applying to dream schools.

Simple solution concept: A tool that estimates admissions difficulty using GPA, test scores, curriculum, activities, intended major, and historical admit ranges.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 9/10

Target School Deadline Tracker

Specific problem: Different schools have different deadlines for Early Decision, Early Action, Regular Decision, scholarships, and documents.

Why this persona cares: International students often apply across multiple systems and can easily miss requirements.

Simple solution concept: A dashboard that tracks all deadlines by school and sends reminders before each due date.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 9/10

Required Materials Checklist

Specific problem: Students are unsure which materials each school requires.

Why this persona cares: Requirements may include transcripts, test scores, essays, recommendation letters, portfolios, financial documents, and English proficiency scores.

Simple solution concept: A school-specific checklist that shows required, optional, and missing materials.

Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 10/10

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Likelihood this is a real, painful problem: 9/10

Quick Lean Canvas

Lean Startup Canvas 1: Personalized Fit-Based School List

Problem:

International students do not know which U.S. colleges are realistic, safe, or ambitious for their profile. Many students rely too heavily on rankings, school name recognition, or advice from friends and agencies without understanding personal fit.

Solution:

A personalized school list tool that creates a balanced list of reach, target, and safety schools based on the student's academic profile, intended major, budget, location preferences, and application goals.

Target User:

International high school students applying to U.S. undergraduate programs, especially students who are applying independently or with limited school counseling support.

1. Problem

International students struggle to identify schools that match their academic profile and goals.

Students often do not know how to balance reach, target, and safety schools.

Students may waste time and money applying to schools that are unrealistic or poor fits.

2. Solution

Generate a personalized school list based on student profile and preferences.

Categorize schools into reach, target, and safety groups.

Explain why each school is recommended, including fit factors such as major, cost, location, and admissions difficulty.

3. Unique Value Proposition

A personalized U.S. college matching tool that helps international students build a realistic and balanced school list instead of relying only on rankings.

4. Unfair Advantage

The platform can combine admissions data, school information, and international student-specific factors in one place. Over time, user behavior and feedback can improve recommendation quality.

5. Customer Segments

Primary users: International high school students applying to U.S. undergraduate programs.

Secondary users: Parents of international applicants.

Possible early adopters: Students applying without expensive college counselors, especially juniors and seniors in high school.

6. Key Metrics

Number of students who complete their profile.

Number of school lists generated.

Number of schools saved per student.

Percentage of users who return to edit or refine their list.

User rating of recommendation usefulness.

7. Channels

International student communities.

High school student groups.

TikTok, Instagram, Xiaohongshu, Reddit, Discord, and WeChat groups.

Partnerships with international schools or student organizations.

SEO content about U.S. college application planning.

8. Cost Structure

School data collection and maintenance.

Product development and hosting.

AI or matching algorithm costs.

Marketing and user acquisition.

Customer support and content moderation.

9. Revenue Streams

Freemium model with basic school matching for free.

Paid premium version with deeper comparison, advanced filters, and exportable application plans.

Possible subscription for students during application season.

Possible partnerships with schools or education organizations, as long as recommendations remain transparent.

Assumptions That Need Validation

Students will trust a school matching platform enough to use it for application planning.

Students want reach, target, and safety categorization.

Students are willing to enter detailed personal information.

Students and parents may pay for more advanced matching or planning features.

The platform can access or maintain reliable enough data to make useful recommendations.

Lean Startup Canvas 2: Admissions Difficulty Estimator

Problem:

International students have trouble understanding how competitive a U.S. college is for their individual profile. They may know a school's overall acceptance rate, but they do not know what that means for their grades, test scores, curriculum, activities, intended major, and international background.

Solution:

An admissions difficulty estimator that gives students a realistic difficulty rating for each school based on their profile and available admissions data.

Target User:

International students applying to U.S. undergraduate programs who are trying to decide whether a school is a reach, target, or safety option.

1. Problem

Students do not understand how competitive specific schools are for their profile.

Overall acceptance rates are too general and can be misleading.

Students may build unrealistic school lists without understanding admissions risk.

2. Solution

Estimate admissions difficulty using GPA, test scores, curriculum, activities, intended major, and historical admit ranges.

Show difficulty levels such as high reach, reach, target, likely, or safety.

Explain the main factors that make a school more or less difficult for the student.

3. Unique Value Proposition

A realistic admissions difficulty tool that helps international students understand their chances more clearly and build smarter application strategies.

4. Unfair Advantage

The platform can focus specifically on international applicants, whose admissions context is different from domestic applicants. If users provide outcomes over time, the platform can improve its estimates.

5. Customer Segments

Primary users: International high school students building their college lists.

Secondary users: Parents who want a more realistic view of admissions chances.

Possible early adopters: Students applying to selective U.S. colleges and students without strong counseling support.

6. Key Metrics

Number of difficulty estimates generated.

Number of users who save or compare estimated schools.

Accuracy of difficulty categories compared with later outcomes.

User trust rating for the estimate.

Percentage of users who adjust their school list after seeing estimates.

7. Channels

College application forums and online communities.

International school counselor networks.

Search content about acceptance rates and school list strategy.

Social media content explaining reach, target, and safety schools.

Referral from students who use the school matching feature.

8. Cost Structure

Admissions data collection and cleaning.

Algorithm development.

AI or data processing costs.

Legal and ethical review to avoid misleading claims.

Marketing and support.

9. Revenue Streams

Free basic difficulty estimate.

Paid advanced estimate with detailed explanation and strategy suggestions.

Bundled premium plan with school matching and application planning.

Possible school list review service as an add-on.

Assumptions That Need Validation

Students want an admissions difficulty estimate even if it cannot guarantee results.

Students understand that the tool provides guidance, not a guaranteed probability.

Enough reliable data is available to make useful estimates.

Users will be willing to provide personal academic and extracurricular information.

Difficulty estimates will change student behavior in a helpful way.

Lean Startup Canvas 3: Target School Deadline Tracker

Problem:

Different U.S. colleges have different deadlines for Early Decision, Early Action, Regular Decision, scholarships, financial aid, testing, and required documents. International students applying to multiple schools can easily miss important deadlines.

Solution:

A deadline tracking dashboard that organizes all deadlines by target school and sends reminders before each due date.

Target User:

International students applying to multiple U.S. undergraduate programs, especially students managing the process independently.

1. Problem

Students must manage many deadlines across different schools.

Deadlines vary by application plan, scholarship, financial aid, and document type.

Missing one deadline can seriously hurt an application.

2. Solution

Create a personalized deadline dashboard based on the student's target schools.

Track ED, EA, RD, scholarship, financial aid, test score, recommendation letter, and document deadlines.

Send reminders before each deadline and show upcoming tasks in order of urgency.

3. Unique Value Proposition

A centralized deadline tracker built specifically for international students applying to multiple U.S. colleges.

4. Unfair Advantage

The platform can connect deadline tracking with school matching, required materials, and application progress, making it more useful than a generic calendar.

5. Customer Segments

Primary users: International high school seniors applying to U.S. colleges.

Secondary users: Parents helping students manage applications.

Possible early adopters: Students applying to 8 or more schools.

6. Key Metrics

Number of schools added to tracker.

Number of deadlines tracked per user.

Reminder open rate.

Percentage of tasks completed before deadline.

User retention during application season.

7. Channels

Application planning content.

International student online communities.

School counseling groups.

Search results for “college application deadline tracker.”

Referrals from students using school list or materials checklist features.

8. Cost Structure

Deadline data collection and updates.

Product development and notification system.

Hosting and database costs.

Email or SMS reminder costs.

Customer support.

9. Revenue Streams

Free basic deadline tracker.

Paid premium reminders, calendar sync, and advanced planning tools.

Subscription during application season.

Bundle with school matching and materials checklist.

Assumptions That Need Validation

Students currently struggle enough with deadlines to use a separate tool.

Students will manually add target schools or import them from another feature.

Reminder notifications will reduce missed deadlines.

Users prefer a college-specific tracker over Google Calendar or Notion.

Students may pay for more reliable reminders and planning features.

Lean Startup Canvas 4: Required Materials Checklist

Problem:

International students are often unsure which materials each U.S. college requires. Requirements may include transcripts, test scores, essays, recommendation letters, portfolios, financial documents, English proficiency scores, and school-specific supplements.

Solution:

A school-specific checklist that shows required, optional, and missing materials for each target school.

Target User:

International students applying to U.S. undergraduate programs who need to manage application materials across multiple schools.

1. Problem

Students do not know exactly which materials each school requires.

Requirements differ across schools and can be difficult to find.

Students may submit incomplete applications or waste time preparing unnecessary materials.

2. Solution

Create a checklist for each school showing required, optional, and missing materials.

Group materials by category, such as essays, tests, transcripts, recommendations, financial documents, and supplements.

Allow students to mark progress and see what still needs attention.

3. Unique Value Proposition

A clear school-by-school materials checklist that helps international students avoid confusion and incomplete applications.

4. Unfair Advantage

The checklist can be connected with the deadline tracker and school profile snapshot, creating a complete application management system.

5. Customer Segments

Primary users: International high school students applying to several U.S. colleges.

Secondary users: Parents and school counselors helping students track materials.

Possible early adopters: Students applying independently or applying to schools with complex requirements.

6. Key Metrics

Number of checklists created.

Number of materials marked complete.

Percentage of users who return to update progress.

Number of missing items flagged.

User-reported reduction in confusion or stress.

7. Channels

Student application communities.

Search content about required application materials.

Partnerships with school counselors or international student groups.

Social media posts about common application mistakes.

Cross-promotion from deadline tracker and school matching features.

8. Cost Structure

School requirement data collection and maintenance.

Product development.

Database and hosting costs.

Notification system costs.

Customer support and content updates.

9. Revenue Streams

Free basic checklist.

Paid advanced version with reminders, document upload tracking, and progress export.

Seasonal subscription for application planning.

Bundle with deadline tracker and admissions difficulty estimator.

Assumptions That Need Validation

Students find school requirements confusing enough to need a dedicated checklist.

The platform can maintain accurate and updated requirements.

Students will regularly update their checklist progress.

Users may pay for advanced tracking or reminders.

A checklist can reduce application mistakes and stress.

Lean Startup Canvas 5: School Profile Snapshot

Problem:

Students need a quick way to understand a school before deciding whether to research it more deeply. Researching every school from scratch takes too much time, especially when information is spread across official websites, rankings, student reviews, and forums.

Solution:

A one-page school snapshot that summarizes admissions difficulty, cost, strongest majors, location, international student percentage, deadlines, and key pros and cons.

Target User:

International students in the early and middle stages of building a U.S. college list.

1. Problem

Students spend too much time researching each school from scratch.

Important school information is spread across many websites.

Students need a quick way to decide whether a school is worth deeper research.

2. Solution

Create a one-page profile for each school.

Include key information such as admissions difficulty, cost, strongest majors, location, international student percentage, deadlines, and pros and cons.

Use a consistent format so students can compare schools quickly.

3. Unique Value Proposition

A fast, clear school snapshot that helps international students understand and compare U.S. colleges without getting lost in scattered information.

4. Unfair Advantage

The platform can design school profiles specifically around international student needs, not just general U.S. applicant information.

5. Customer Segments

Primary users: International students researching U.S. colleges.

Secondary users: Parents comparing schools with their children.

Possible early adopters: Students who are overwhelmed by long school websites and rankings.

6. Key Metrics

Number of school profiles viewed.

Time spent on each school profile.

Number of schools saved after viewing snapshots.

Number of comparisons made between schools.

User rating of profile clarity and usefulness.

7. Channels

SEO pages for school profiles.

Social media content comparing schools.

International student forums and communities.

Referrals from school matching results.

Content marketing around “best fit” schools for international students.

8. Cost Structure

School data collection and updating.

Content writing and editing.

Product design and hosting.

Data sourcing from official and public sources.

User review moderation if student perspectives are included.

9. Revenue Streams

Free basic school profiles.

Paid premium profiles with deeper insights, comparison tools, and student reviews.

Advertising or sponsorships only if clearly labeled and separated from recommendations.

Subscription bundle with school matching, deadline tracker, and materials checklist.

Assumptions That Need Validation

Students want short school summaries before deeper research.

The selected data points are the most important ones for international students.

Students will trust a platform-generated school profile.

Users may pay for deeper comparisons or premium profile details.

The platform can keep profile information accurate and updated.

Top Two Ideas

Idea 1: Personalized Fit-Based School List

International students applying to U.S. undergraduate programs often struggle to know which schools are realistic, safe, or ambitious for their profile. This problem is especially common for students who are applying independently, have limited access to experienced college counselors, or are unfamiliar with the U.S. admissions system. They care because applying to the wrong mix of schools can waste time and application fees, increase stress, and reduce their chances of ending up at a school that truly fits their academic goals, budget, and personal preferences.

Idea 2: School Profile Snapshot

International students often need to research many U.S. colleges, but the information is scattered across official websites, rankings, forums, social media, and student reviews. This problem affects students who are still building their college list and need a quick way to understand whether a school is worth researching more deeply. They care because researching every school from scratch takes too much time, and missing key information about cost, location, majors, deadlines, or international student support can lead to poor application decisions.